

A Child's Primer



of Natural
History

1834
H. W. Harper

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A Child's Primer Of Natural History



By Oliver Herford

**with Pictures by
the Author**

Charles Scribner's Sons, New York, 1899

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A Seal.

SEE, chil-dren, the Fur-bear-ing Seal;
Ob-serve his mis-di-rect-ed zeal:
He dines with most ab-ste-mi-ous care
On Fish, Ice Water and Fresh Air
A-void-ing cond-i-ments or spice,
For fear his fur should not be nice
And fine and smooth and soft and meet
For Broad-way or for Re-gent Street
And yet some-how I of-ten feel
(Though for the kind Fur-bear-ing Seal
I har-bor a Re-spect Pro-found)

The Giraffe.

SEE the Gi-raffe; he is so tall
There is not room to get him all
U-pon the page. His head is high-er—
The pic-ture proves it—than the Spire.

That's why the natives, when they race
 To catch him, call it stee-ple-chase.
 His chief de-light it is to set
 A good example: shine or wet
 He rises ere the break of day,
 And starts his break-fast right away.
 His food has such a way to go,—
 His throat's so very long,—and so
 An early break-fast he must munch
 To get it down ere time for lunch.



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The Yak.

THIS is the Yak, so neg-li-gée:
 His coif-fure's like a stack of hay;
 He lives so far from Any-where,
 I fear the Yak neg-lects his hair,
 And thinks, since there is none to see,
 What mat-ter how un-kempt he be.
 How would he feel if he but knew
 That in this Pic-ture-book I drew
 His Phys-i-og-no-my un-shorn,
 For chil-dren to de-ride and scorn?



A Whale.

THE
con-
sci-en-
tious
art-ist
tries
On-ly
to
draw
what
meets
his
eyes.
This is
the
Whale
; he
seems
to be
A
spout
of wa-
ter in
the
sea.
Now,
Hux-
ley
from
one
bone
could
make
An un-
known

beast; so if I take
This spout of wa-ter, and from thence
Con-struct a Whale by in-fer-ence,
A Whale, I ven-ture to as-sert,
Must be an an-i-mat-ed squirt!
Thus, chil-dren, we the truth may sift
By use of Log-ic's Price-less Gift.



The Leopard.



THIS is the Le-o-pard, my child;
 His tem-per's any-thing but mild.
 The Le-o-pard can't change his spots,
 And that—so say the Hot-ten-tots—
 Is why he is so wild.
 Year in, year out, he may not change,
 No mat-ter how the wea-ther range,
 From cold to hot. No won-der, child,
 We hear the Le-o-pard is wild.

The Sloth.

THE Sloth en-joys a life of Ease;
 He hangs in-vert-ed from the trees,
 And views life up-side down.
 If you, my child, are noth-ing loath
 To live in In-dol-ence and Sloth,
 Un-heed-ing the World's frown,
 You, too, un-vexed by Toil and Strife,
 May take a hu-mor-ous view of life.

The Elephant.

THIS is the El-e-phant, who lives
 With but one aim—to please.
 His i-vo-ry tusk he free-ly gives
 To make pi-a-no keys.
 One grief he has—how-e'er he tries,
 He nev-er can for-get
 That one of his e-nor-mous size
 Can't be a house-hold pet.
 Then does he to his grief give way,
 Or sink 'neath sor-row's ban?
 Oh, no; in-stead he spends each day
 Con-tri-ving some un-sel-fish way
 To be of use to Man.



The Pig-Pen.

OH, turn not from the hum-ble Pig,
My child, or think him in-fra dig.
We oft hear lit-er-a-ry men
Boast of the in-flu-ence of the Pen;
Yet when we read in His-to-ry's Page
Of Hu-man Pigs in ev-er-y age,
From Cr[oe]sus to the pres-ent day,
Is it, my child, so hard to say
(De-spite the Scribes' vain-glo-ri-ous boast)
What Pen has in-flu-enced Man the most?

Some Geese.



EV-ER-Y child who has the use
Of his sen-ses knows a goose.
See them un-der-neath the tree
Gath-er round the goose-girl's knee,
While she reads them by the hour
From the works of Scho-pen-hau-er.
How pa-tient-ly the geese at-tend!
But do they re-al-ly com-pre-hend
What Scho-pen-hau-er's driv-ing at?
Oh, not at all; but what of that?
Nei-ther do I; nei-ther does she;
And, for that mat-ter, nor does he.

The Ant.

MY child, ob-serve the use-ful Ant,
How hard she works each day.
She works as hard as ad-a-mant
(That's very hard, they say).
She has no time to gal-li-vant;
She has no time to play.
Let Fido chase his tail all day;
Let Kitty play at tag:
She has no time to throw a-way,
She has no tail to wag.
She scurries round from morn till night;
She ne-ver, ne-ver sleeps;
She seiz-es ev-ery-thing in sight,
And drags it home with all her might,
And all she takes she keeps.

An Arctic Hare.

AN Arc-
tic Hare
we now
be-hold.

The
hair, you
will ob-
serve, is
white;
But if you
think the
Hare is
old,

You will
be ver-y
far from
right.

The Hare
is young,
and yet the
hair

Grew
white in
but a sin-
gle night.
Why, then
it must
have been
a scare

That
turned this
Hare. No;
't was not
fright

(Al-though such cases are well known);

I fear that once a-gain you're wrong.

Know then, that in the Arc-tic Zone

A sin-gle night is six months long.



The Wolf.

OH, yes, the Wolf is bad, it's true;
But how with-out him could we do?
If there were not a wolf, what good



Would be the tale of RID-ING-HOOD?
The Lit-tle Child from sin will fly
When told the wick-ed Wolf is nigh;
And when, ar-rived at Man's es-tate,
He hears the Wolf out-side his gate,
He knows it's time to put a-way
I-dle fri-vol-i-ty and play.
That's how (but do not men-tion it)
This prim-er hap-pened to be writ.

An Ostrich.

THIS is an Os-trich. See him stand:

His head is bur-ied in the sand.
It is not that he seeks for food,
Nor is he shy, nor is he rude;
But he is sen-si-tive, and shrinks
And hides his head when-e'er he thinks
How, on the Gains-bor-ough hat some day
Of some fine la-dy at the play,
His fea-thers may ob-struct the view
Of all the stage from me or you.

The Hippopotamus.

"OH, say, what is this fearful, wild
In-cor-ri-gible cuss?"
"This _crea-ture_ (don't say 'cuss,' my child;
'T is slang)—this crea-ture fierce is styled The Hip-po-pot-am-us.
His curious name de-rives its source
From two Greek words: _hippos_—a horse,
Potamos—river. See?
The river's plain e-nough, of course;
But why they called that thing a horse,
That's what is Greek to me."



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The Fly.

OB-SERVE, my child, the House-hold Fly,
With his ex-traor-di-na-ry eye:
What-ev-er thing he may be-hold
Is mul-ti-plied a thou-sand-fold.
We do not need a com-plex eye
When we ob-serve the Household Fly:
He is so vol-a-tile that he
In _ev-ery_ place at once can be;
He is the buzz-ing in-car-na-tion
Of an-i-mate mul-ti-pli-ca-tion.
Ah! chil-dren, who can tell the Why
And Where-fore of the House-hold Fly?



The Mongoos.

THIS, Chil-dren, is the famed Mon-goos.
He has an ap-pe-tite ab-struse;
Strange to re-late, this crea-ture takes
A cu-ri-ous joy in eat-ing snakes—
All kinds, though, it must be con-fessed,
He likes the poi-son-ous ones the best.
From him we learn how ve-ry small
A thing can bring a-bout a Fall.
Oh, Mon-goos, where were you that day
When Mis-tress Eve was led a-stray?
If you'd but seen the ser-pent first,
Our Parents would not have been cursed,
And so there would be no ex-cuse
For MIL-TON, but for you—Mon-goos!

The Platypus.

MY child, the Duck-billed Plat-y-pus
A sad ex-am-ple sets for us:
From him we learn how In-de-ci-sion
Of char-ac-ter pro-vokes De-ri-sion.
This vac-il-lat-ing Thing, you see,
Could not de-cide which he would be,
Fish, Flesh, or Fowl, and chose all three.
The sci-en-tists were sore-ly vexed
To clas-si-fy him; so per-plexed
Their brains that they, with Rage at bay,
Called him a hor-rid name one day,—
A name that baf-fles, frights, and shocks us,—
Or-ni-tho-rhyn-chus Par-a-dox-us.



The Chimpanzee.

CHIL-DREN, be-hold the Chim-pan-zee:
He sits on the an-ces-tral tree
From which we sprang in ag-es gone.
I'm glad we sprang: had we held on,
We might, for aught that I can say,
Be hor-rid Chim-pan-zees to-day.

A Mole.



SEE, chil-dren, the mis-guid-ed Mole.
 He lives down in a deep, dark hole;
 Sweet-ness, and Light, and good Fresh Air
 Are things for which he does not care.
 He has not e-ven that make-shift
 Of fee-ble minds—the _so-cial gift_.
 But say not that he has no soul,
 Lest hap-ly we misjudge the Mole;
 Nay, if we mea-sure him by Men,
 No doubt he sits in his dark den
 In-struct-ing oth-ers blind as he
 Ex-act-ly how the world _should_ be.

The Rhinoceros.

SO this is the Rhi-no-ce-ros!
 I won-der why he looks so cross.
 Per-haps he is an-noyed a bit

Be-cause his cloth-ing does not fit.
 (They say he got it read-y made!)
 It is not that, I am a-fraid.
 He looks so cross be-cause I drew
 Him with one horn in-stead of two.

Well, since he cares so much for style,
 Let's give him two and see him smile.

A Penguin.

THE Pen-guin sits up-on the shore
 And loves the lit-tle fish to bore;
 He has one en-er-vat-ing joke
 That would a very Saint pro-voke:
 "The Pen-guin's might-i-er than the Sword-fish";
 He tells this dai-ly to the bored fish,
 Un-til they are so weak, they float
 With-out re-sis-tance down his throat.



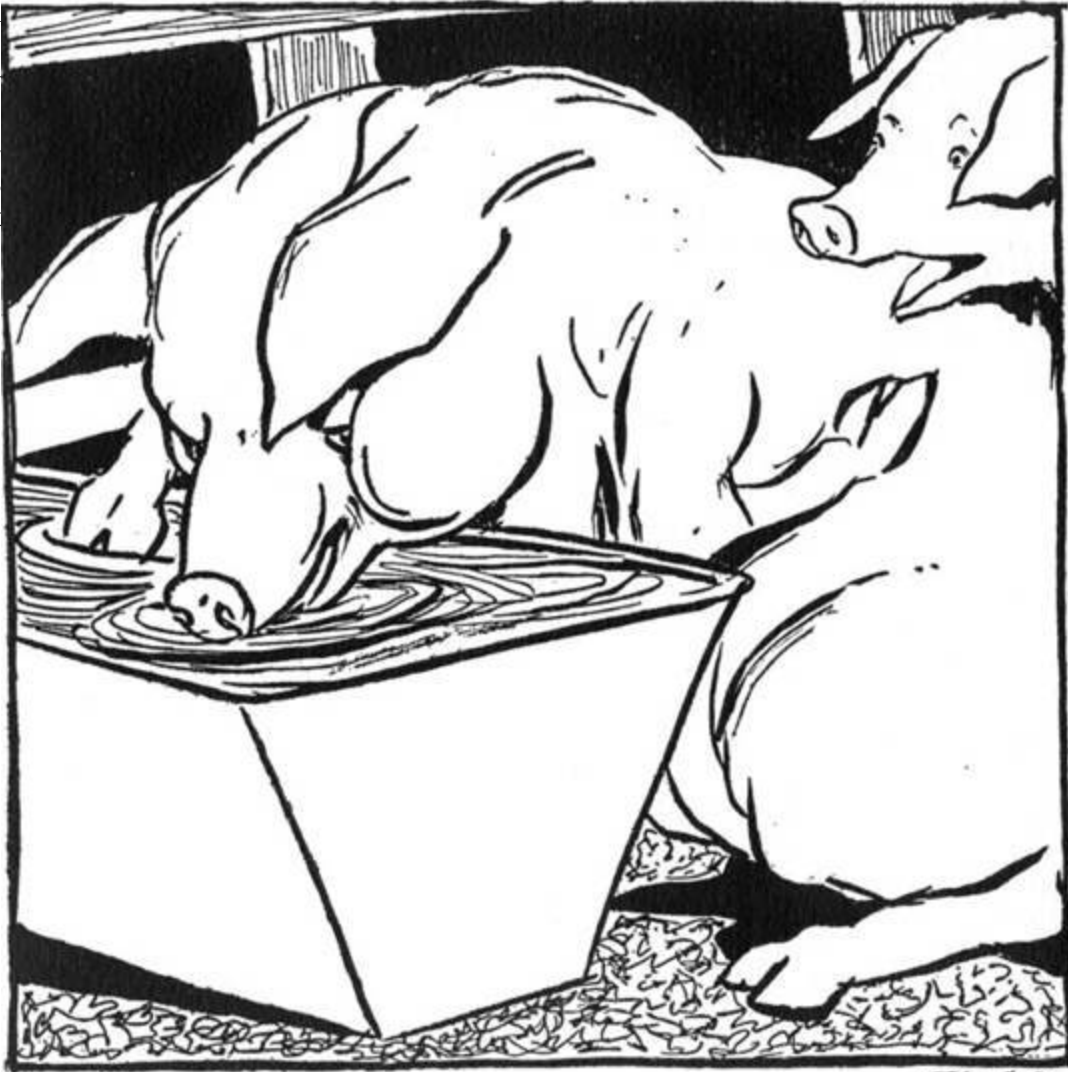
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The Cat.

OB-SERVE the Cat up-on this page.
 Phil-os-o-phers in ev-er-y age,
 The ver-y _wis-est_ of the wise,
 Have tried her mind to an-a-lyze
 In vain, for noth-ing can they learn.
 She baf-fles them at ev-er-y turn
 Like Mis-ter Ham-let in the play.
 She leads their rea-son-ing a-stray;
 She feigns an in-ter-est in string
 Or yarn or any roll-ing thing.
 Un-like the Dog, she does not care
 With com-mon Man her thoughts to share.
 She teach-es us that in life's walk
 'T is bet-ter to let oth-ers talk,



And lis-ten
while
they say
in-stead
The fool-
ish things
we might
have said.



Handwritten signature

The Dog.

HERE is the Dog. Since time be-gan,
The Dog has been the friend of MAN,
The Dog loves MAN be-cause he shears
His coat and clips his tail and ears.
MAN loves the Dog be-cause he'll stay
And lis-ten to his talk all day,
And wag his tail and show de-light
At all his jokes, how-ev-er trite.
His bark is far worse than his bite,
So peo-ple say. They may be right;
Yet if to make a choice I had,
I'd choose his bark, how-ev-er bad.



A Chameleon.

A USE-FUL les-son you may con,
My Child, from the Cha-me-le-on:
He has the gift, ex-treme-ly rare
In an-i-mals, of sav-oir-faire.
And if the se-cret you would guess
Of the Cha-me-le-on's suc-cess,

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